Prospect; Fear of Poison Rain; Vegetables May be Contaminated; and other horrific reports round out the picture. The gutter press like Bild quote from each other, hoping perhaps to enhance their credibility. They run all this under the headline of Nuclear Catastrophe and want to send chills up your spine. The very mention of Moscow is meant to frighten Bild readers.

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In the midst of the disaster, the growing environmentalist movement became markedly more hostile against nuclear energy, especially given East Germany had a nuclear power station at Greismald, 120km from the south coast of Denmark. Activists also decried the flagrant abuse of nature, factories bellowing out gaseous mixtures, increasing militarisation and urban decay – many historic buildings around the country had gone to seed. True to form, as the government downplayed Chernobyl, it also brushed aside concerns about smog, acid rain and damage to forests.

Later that year, protest action by Greenpeace activists took place in front of the GDR Ministry of the Environment against the leaching of salt into the Werra River from potash mines in Thuringia, where an average daily quantity of 40,000 tons of brine was dumped into the river, leaving it nearly dead biologically. For campaigners, the appalling effects of environmental neglect could be seen in soot-covered Bitterfeld, in the district of Saxony-Anhalt where chemical factories – using coal-based products to manufacture pesticides, dyes and plastics – turned the town and surrounding region into a hazardous landscape. Ash, soot and dust, chlorine and hydrochloric acid were just a few of the highly toxic substances belched out into the atmosphere.

Most alarming, eye ailments, together with lung and skin diseases were common. Physicians noticed the children of Bitterfeld showed differences in size and weight and that girls showed delayed bone development.